

Insight and Social Being¹

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Being is the unknown that
questioning intends to know, that
answers partially reveal, that
further questioning presses on to
know more fully.

The Subject

BERNARD LONERGAN

1 Introduction

This paper contributes to the philosophy of social ontology. Work in this area seeks to expand our understanding of the nature of social facts. By “social fact” is typically meant a true state of affairs in which collective intentionality plays a constitutive role. While the preferred concept of “collective intentionality” varies substantially from author to author, the common aim is to describe intentions (beliefs, objectives, desires) that are somehow shared among a referent group of people. To take a canonical example, the statement, “It is the case that this one-dollar bill issued by the U.S. Treasury is legal tender within the United States,” would be a social fact if true. It is *social* in the sense that the truth of the statement requires that citizens of the United States collectively intend that bills so issued do serve as legal tender. Without the addition of the collective intention, such bills have no powers beyond their physical properties as elaborately inked pieces of paper.

Much of the activity in this area traces to the important contributions of Gilbert, Searle, and Tuomela in the 1990s.¹ Recently, a number of book-length treatments have appeared. Lest there be any doubt that things are getting serious, 2015 debuted *The Journal of Social Ontology*. Open issues of active investigation include the nature of collective intentions, the relevant categories of social facts and their distinguishing characteristics, the essence of

¹Gilbert1992; Searle1995; Tuomela1995.

language as a social institution, and group agency. While social ontology is an active and growing area of philosophical investigation, it is not, however, the only context in which questions of this kind have been posed. The ancients were keenly interested in the polity, the scholastics were captivated with theology and law, and the concerns of early modern philosophers included political philosophy and economics – all of which require some philosophical stance toward social states of affairs. That said, the contemporary work on social ontology appears to be novel in its explicit attention to social facts broadly construed.

The motivation for this paper stems from the observation that the field’s intellectual resources are overwhelmingly directed toward understanding the *structure* of social facts. This comes at the expense of a more aggressive exploration of the causes of such facts. The result is a mushrooming typology of social facts based upon their myriad features, within which a deeper understanding of category relationships remains elusive without a unifying explanatory framework (e.g., it is difficult to know whether distinctions between categories like intrinsic vs. observer-relative, objective vs. subjective, ontologic vs. epistemic, and institutional vs. non-institutional are superficial, or essential at some metaphysically deep level). The structural focus also leads to the stipulation of, apparently, ad hoc philosophical objects designed to stand in for missing explanations (e.g., Searle’s “Background”). Further, within this fragmented status quo arise a number puzzling issues (e.g., the circularity of the language as a social institution necessary for this existence of social institutions).

To be clear, we are not attributing any particular novelty to the preceding observation – all of the issues mentioned in the preceding paragraph are already identified, in one form or another, by social ontologists themselves. Rather, our aim is to contribute to the explanatory component of the discussion. To do this, we adopt a well-formulated account of human intelligence to explain the genesis of several important categories of social facts. This, we claim, *is* novel. At present, we can find no explicit appeal to human intelligence as an explanatory factor in the existence of social being. We suspect the reason for this is the open commitment of many of the central figures in the field to a reductive view of the human mind.

That is, a strong commitment to the reducibility of mental processes to chemical events in brains which evolved through random physical processes may have induced certain blind spots with respect to the causal role of human intelligence in the genesis of social facts.

Our purpose here is not to litigate alternative philosophies of mind. Rather – whatever the structure of mind one favors – healthy humans possess a manifest capacity for intelligent inquiry, understanding, and judgment. We contend that explicit consideration of these powers in the analysis of social facts provides a unifying explanatory foundation and, in the process, resolves several ontological puzzles. We proceed by adopting Lonergan’s characterization of cognitional structure.² Lonergan was a mid-20th Century philosopher and theologian who was attempting to bring older traditions in philosophy into conversation with modern natural and social sciences. He believed that there was great potential to be had in revisiting important ideas from the older philosophical traditions and relating them to the rapid expansion of knowledge that accompanied the rise widespread diffusion of the scientific method. The result of his effort is a richly articulated account of human intelligence. In our judgment, this account provides a potentially fruitful analytical framework for issues in social ontology. At the same time, because Lonergan’s primary interests were mathematics and the natural sciences, the application of these ideas to social facts should prove illuminating and fecund on both sides.

The paper has five steps. The first is to introduce several prevalent ideas in the recent stream on social ontology. An exhaustive review is beyond the scope of this paper. Rather, we summarize several points in what we hope is a noncontroversial fashion, highlighting several recognized puzzles and issues along the way. Second, we introduce our approach and attempt to cut through some confusion about the objectivity of what are called ‘social facts’. Third, we discuss meaning as an intrinsic constituent of social reality. Fourth, we discuss

²Bernard J. F. Lonergan, *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding*, ed. Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran, vol. 3, *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan* (Toronto: University of Toronto, 1992); Bernard J. F. Lonergan, *Method in Theology* (New York: Herder and Herder, 1972); Bernard J. F. Lonergan, *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas*, ed. Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran (Toronto: University of Toronto, 1997).

collective intentionality and the possibility, not only of socially constructed objects, but also of a socially constructed subject. Fifth, finally, we consider some peculiarities about the kind of social reality that is a formal social organization.

2 Overview of the literature: issues and puzzles

The focal objects of social ontology are “social facts.” That is, there appear to be objective facts in the real world

...that are only facts by human agreement. In a sense there are things that exist only because we believe them to exist. I am thinking of things like money, property, governments, and marriages. Yet many facts regarding these things are ‘objective’ facts in the sense that they are not a matter of your or my preferences, evaluations, or moral attitudes. I am thinking of such facts as that I am a citizen of the United States, that the piece of paper in my pocket is a five-dollar bill, that my younger sister got married on December 14, that I own a piece of property in Berkely, and that the New York Giants won the 1991 Superbowl. These contrast with such facts as that Mount Everest has snow and ice near the summit or that hydrogen atoms have one electron, which are facts totally independent of any human opinions.³

The existence of such facts pose a puzzle: whether and, if so, how a thing can have an objective existence when one of the conditions required for this existence is a subjective belief that the thing really does exist? How do realities constituted by human intentionality (conceiving, affirming, desiring, etc.) have an objective existence?

In the following discussion, we examine Searle’s (1995) line of analysis in answer to these questions. Searle’s account is consistent with – if not foundational to – many of the extant

³Searle, *The Construction of Social Reality*, 1–2.

themes in the present line of social ontology.⁴ Thus, although our discussion is particular to Searle, this particularity should not be read as targeting him per se. Rather, by following the flow of his argument in some detail, we hope to illustrate certain patterns of thought that are present in the literature more generally.

A multitude of social beings As mentioned in the Introduction, a *social fact* is a true state of affairs in which collective intentionality plays a constitutive role. According to Searle, a *collective intentionality* an intention that is expressed in the form of a plural noun phrase; e.g., “We intend to play a duet.”⁵ For him, collective intentionality is a “biologically primitive phenomenon that cannot be reduced to or eliminated in favor of something else.” The essential feature is that the parties involved “have a sense of doing (wanting, believing, etc.) something together.” Social facts are distinguished from *brute facts*, which are features of the universe that exist independently of what any human thinks about them; i.e., realities that are “out there,” constituted physics and biology and not matters of culture and society.⁶

To get to social facts, certain preliminaries are required. First, it is stipulated that, “we live in a world made up entirely of physical particles in fields of force. Some of these are organized into systems. Some of these systems are living systems and some of these living systems have evolved consciousness. With consciousness comes intentionality, the capacity of the organism to represent objects and states of affairs in the world to itself.”⁷ This premise leads to a number of distinctions, most basically those between the *objective* and the *subjective*. Searle distinguishes two perspectives from which we consider the objective and subjective – the *epistemic* and the *ontological*. The former refers to the predicates of *judgments*. For example, the judgment that Thomas Aquinas is a Doctor of the Catholic

⁴Bratman2014; Gilbert2013; Pratten2014; Tollefsen2015; Here, we have in mind work by Christian List/Philip Pettit: Group agency: the possibility, design, and status of corporate agents, Oxford 2011; S Miller: The moral foundations of social institutions: A philosophical study, Cambridge 2010; Raimo Tuomela: Social Ontology: Collective Intentionality and Group Agents, Oxford 2013, pp. 1–41.

⁵Searle1995.

⁶Searle1995.

⁷Searle1995.

Church is *epistemically objective*. Its truth is a simple matter of fact. The judgment that Aquinas is the best of the scholastic philosophers *epistemically subjective* because its truth depends upon the attitudes of those making the judgment. The latter sense, ontological, refers to predicates of entities that ascribe modes of existence. Entities are *ontologically subjective* when their existence depends upon the perceptions of a subject mind. They are *ontologically objective* when their existence does not depend upon any such perceptions.

In the context of this scheme, a “more fundamental” distinction can be introduced: features of the world that exist independently of humans versus those that are dependent upon us for their existence.’⁸ The idea is that entities in the world can be said to have features that are *intrinsic* to nature (e.g., mass, chemical composition) versus those that are *observer-relative*. i.e., features that are relative to the intentionalities of observers. Thus, we have statements like,

The existence of observer-relative features of the world does not add any new material objects to reality, but it can add epistemically objective features to reality where the features in question exist relative to observers and users. It is, for example, an epistemically objective feature of this thing that it is a screwdriver, but that feature exists only relative to observers and users, and so the feature is ontologically subjective.⁹

Summing up, Searle makes three, interrelated distinctions between: i) the intrinsic and the observer-relative; ii) ontological objectivity and subjectivity; and, iii) epistemic objectivity and subjectivity. Thus, “for any observer-relative feature F , seeming to be F is logically prior to being F , because – appropriately understood – seeming to be F is a necessary condition of being F .”¹⁰

Central to Searle’s account is the introduction of the notion of *assignment functions*.

⁸Searle1995.

⁹Searle1995.

¹⁰Searle1995.

The idea is that natural and artificially produced phenomena can be assigned intentional functions, functions that transcend the physical features of the target phenomenon. For example, I may decide to use a particular tree stump as a “chair” during a long hike in the Adirondacks. Searle makes the strong claim that such functions are *always* observer-relative. This conforms to Searle’s philosophical presupposition that there is no ontology in nature, “but except for those parts of nature that are conscious, nature knows nothing of functions.”¹¹ Thus, for example, Searle is fine with the claim that the intrinsic nature of the heart is that it pumps blood, but not with the claim that the function of the heart is to pump blood. As he puts it, “One of Darwin’s greatest achievements was to drive teleology out of the account of the origin of species.”¹²

Within the class of functions, Searle wishes to distinguish between *agentive* and *non-agentive* members. The basic idea is to associate the former term with activities that occur in nature independent of human intentions (e.g., a heart pumping blood) and the latter with artificial uses intentionally assigned to objects and phenomena (e.g., using my tie as a coffee blotter). Finally, within the set of agentive functions, one can further distinguish functions that call for an object to stand for or represent something else,

Thus, when I draw a diagram of a football play, I let certain circles stand for the quarterback, the runningback, the offensive linemen, and so on. In this case, the agentive function assigned to the marks on the paper is that of representing or standing for; but because “representing” and “standing for” are just other names for intentionality, in this case we have intentionally imposed intentionality on objects and states of affairs that are not intrinsically intentional. There are names in English for the result of this type of imposition of function: They are called “meaning” or “symbolism.” ... The most famous sorts of meaning are, of

¹¹Searle1995.

¹²Searle1995.

course, in language.¹³

Returning now to social facts, Searle identifies a subclass he refers to as *institutional facts*. By this account, human institutions exist within systems of *constitutive rules*. Some rules, designated *regulative*, “regulate antecedently existing activities.” An example is a country’s norm for driving on one side or the other of the road. In contrast, constitutive rules are rules that “create the very possibility of certain activities.” For example, the rules of chess create the very possibility of playing chess – if one is not following the rules of chess, one is not playing chess. Constitutive rules typically have the form: “*X* counts as *Y* in context *C*.”¹⁴ Again, the claim is that *systems* of rules of this type create the potential for actualizing institutional facts (e.g., Justin Trudeau is the Prime Minister of Canada in 2017). Searle acknowledges that this account raises numerous questions, including: Are all social facts institutional facts?; Are there constitutive rules of, e.g., wars and cocktail parties?; What makes something “constitutive” rule?; How do we connect conscious biological beasts, humans, and the apparatus of social facts and institutions.¹⁵

Appealing to intuition, Searle claims brute facts are always partially constitutive of institutional facts. For example, money, an institution, requires some physical substance in order to function as money: “Institutional facts exist, so to speak, on top of brute physical facts.” It is worth noting that such physical facts include such things as sounds emitted from mouths, ink on paper – “or even thoughts in their [people’s] heads.”¹⁶ Thus,

... the truly radical break with other forms of life comes when humans, through collective intentionality, impose functions on phenomena where the function cannot be achieved solely in virtue of physics and chemistry but requires continued human cooperation in the specific forms of recognition, acceptance, and acknowledgment of a new status to which a function is assigned. This is the beginning

¹³Searle1995.

¹⁴Searle1995.

¹⁵Searle1995.

¹⁶Searle1995.

point of all institutional forms of human culture, and it must always have the structure X counts as Y in context C .”¹⁷

The key claim is that institutional facts are created when collective intentionality assigns a new *status* (Y) to some object or phenomenon (X), the *function* of which cannot be performed solely as a consequence of the intrinsic material features of the target (X).

At this point, we insert our own observation that, while the status function apparatus seems to provide a reasonable way to talk about what we mean by social facts, it requires the construction of an elaborate conceptual structure to support it. Indeed, the preceding six pages of definitions and relationships represent our best attempt at providing the reader with a coherent “executive summary” of that structure. One of the things we hope to illustrate is that, by starting from a basic theory of human intelligence, many of these ideas can be unified and streamlined in a way that, simultaneously, provides a more satisfying explanation of the existence of social facts.

Finally, in addition to the complexity of the explanatory structure, Searle himself notes that his account appears to introduce logical circularity. As he puts it, “how we can define ‘money,’ if part of the definition is ‘being thought of, or regarded as, or believed to be money ... does this not lead to a circularity or infinite regress in any attempt to define the word, or even to give an explanation of the concept of money?’”¹⁸ This is clearly a valid concern that arises from the structure of his account. The “simple” solution, according to Searle, lies in noting that, e.g., the word “money” labels a single “node” within a complex network of practices (e.g., owning property, working for wages, incurring debt, market exchange, etc.). Thus, apparently, the *role* of money can be described without actually using the word “money.” Instead, it is sufficient that one understand the concept of a medium of exchange which, presumably, can be grasped independently via other concepts available to people already familiar with other market-related institutions.

¹⁷Searle1995.

¹⁸Searle1995.

To this, we reply that the circularity problem is not obviated by this reasoning. To see why, let us follow Searle's lead and consider a graph in which the practices and concepts required to define money are, along with money, represented as nodes. Let the concepts and practices sufficient to define money be connected to money via directed arcs. Proceed inductively, first to the concepts and practices required to define the concepts and practices that define money. Connect them with directed arcs. Continue in this fashion until all related concepts and practices are contained in the graph. Presumably, the graph has a finite (though, potentially large) number of nodes. To avoid circularity, the graph must be acyclic. But, if it is acyclic, it contains root nodes. But, if it contains root nodes, there must exist institutional facts that are self-defining. One can relax the requirement that the graph be acyclic, in which case the complex network of practices and concepts is, in some sense, mutually self-defining. However, this raises the issue of the genesis of the complex network in the first place. This issue is related to the problems of language and what Searle refers to as the "Background," both of which we turn to now.

The paradox of language By Searle's account, language is an essential social institution because words are symbolic devices that represent something beyond themselves. This symbolic status is added to spoken sounds or strings of written figures, is the product of constitutive rules according to collective intentions. Furthermore, he makes the strong claim that social institutions are *always* partially constituted by linguistic elements. This claim "amounts to the claim that institutional facts essentially contain some symbolic elements in this sense of 'symbolic': there are words, symbols, or other *conventional* devices that *mean* something or express something or represent or symbolize something beyond themselves, *in a way that is publicly understandable* [p. 60-62, *emph. in original*]." Thus, he argues that social institutions are not available to what he refers to as "prelinguistic" beings.

Searle goes on to distinguish *language-dependent* versus *language-independent facts* and *language-dependent* versus *language-independent thoughts*. He says,

It is a sufficient condition for a fact to be language dependent that two conditions be met. First, mental representations, such as thoughts, must be partly constitutive of the fact; and second, the representations in question must be language dependent. . . . Ask yourself what must be the case in order that it be true that the piece of paper in my hand is a twenty dollar bill or that Tom owns a house, and you will see that there must be mental representations as partly constitutive of these facts. . . . All institutional facts are, in this sense, ontologically subjective, even though in general they are epistemically objective.

The problem with this account is that it, in Searle's words (p. 72), "seems to leave us in a fix." What is this fix? It is that if social institutions require language to exist and language itself is a social institution, then language appears to require language to exist.

The proposed solution to this circularity is the claim that (p. 73), "language doesn't require language in order to be language because it already is language." Presumably, this phrasing is intended to be provocative. By way of explanation, we read (p. 74-75)

The entire argument of this chapter has produced a strange result. I am not entirely comfortable with it, but here it is. The move from X to Y is already linguistic in nature because once the function is imposed on the X element, it now symbolizes something else, the Y function. This move can exist only if it is collectively represented as existing. The collective representation is public and conventional, and it requires some vehicle. Just scrutinizing or imaging the features of the X element will not do the job. So we need words, such as 'money,' 'property,' etc., or we need word-like symbols, such as those we just considered, or in the limiting case we treat the X elements themselves as conventional representations of the Y function. To the extent we can do that, they must be either words or symbols themselves or enough like words to be both bearers of the Y function and representations of the move from X to Y .

Here, we concur with Searle's discomfort. In the next section, we argue that the basic distinction he is groping for here is between being that is constituted by meaning versus being that is not. For example, one might say that a "prelinguistic" dog-society is constituted by meaning in a very restricted sense. There are signs that establish dominance in the pack, etc. But the meaning is strictly intersubjective and not detachable from an intersubjective context in the sense that non-human animals must be within each others' sensoria for the meaning to function intersubjectively. Language, as a tool of meaning, allows meaning to become independent of the intersubjective context. The language-needing-language problem arises when one is inclined to think of language as primitive. Alternatively, we argue below that language is derivative from an important insight: the insight into the possibility of detaching meaning from the intersubjective context. The result is a more elegant, less discomforting account of social being in general and language in particular.

The theory of the "Background" Another issue that arises has to do with awareness of the system of constitutive rules that give structure to human institutions. Specifically, the lion's share of the individuals who participate in the lion's share of the institutions are not consciously aware of the their constitutive rules. The problem this poses is that, if people are generally unaware of the rules to which they must collectively assent in order to constitute the institution in which they wish to participate, how can the institution exist? To provide a solution to this problem, Searle presents the notion of the *Background*, described as "the set of nonintentional or preintentional capacities that enable intentional states of function (p. 129)."

This, in turn, requires definitions for *capacities*, *enabling*, *intentional states*, and *function*. For example, regarding capacities (p. 127), "It is important to see that when we talk about the Background we are talking about a certain category of neurophysiological causation. Because we do not know how these structures function at a neurophysiological level, we are forced to describe them at a much higher level. There is nothing disreputable about

that.” The basic idea is that, in order to be operative, systems of constitutive rules require a supporting set of capacities, knowledge, attitudes and skills. That is, the Background is the phenomenon that permits consistent, interpersonal meaning to attach to the objects of language.

We agree that something like the Background must exist in order for the existence of social being. However, as a mathematician might put it, this account stands as a definition rather than a proposition. That is, the “Background” is a *label* placed on the phenomenon necessarily implied by (not to mention, *experienced* in), e.g., the consistent understanding of language usage within a given social context. The account is not a proposition in the sense that the Background is not the logical conclusion of any set of antecedent criteria. As will be seen, the problem is that this account exhibits a complete oversight of insight and of the coalescence of insights into the nucleus of a common sense. Again, we speculate that the analysis is getting stuck as a result of its preoccupation with the imperative of reducing all events in consciousness to their underlying neurophysiological correlates.¹⁹ Potential explanations that rely upon universally experienced features of human intelligence, such as insight, tend to be overlooked as a result of the overriding belief that all such features are, in any event, reducible to some collection of brain states.

Group agency Finally, let us return briefly to the issue of collective intentionality. As discussed above, collective intentions are constitutive of any social fact. An intention is “collective” when it is associated with a plural subject (“we intend”) rather than a singular subject (“I intend”). It is a universal feature of healthy human cognition that situations involving a shared sense of, e.g., doing something together are distinctly different from those involving individual action. As Searle clarifies (p. 25),

¹⁹A similar reductionism appears to be entailed by Tuomela’s commitment to ‘philosophical naturalism’ as evidenced by the comment, “The theory of this book is based on a science-friendly philosophical naturalism, and is accordingly committed to the idea that major claims of the theory are at least indirectly and partially empirically testable.” Tuomela: Social Ontology: Collective Intentionality and Group Agents (see n. 4), p. 12.

It is indeed the case that all my mental life is inside my brain, and all your mental life is inside your brain, and so on for everybody else. But it does not follow from that that all my mental life must be expressed in the form of a singular noun phrase referring to me. The form that my collective intentionality can take is simply ‘we intend,’ ‘we are doing so-and-so,’ and the like. In such cases, I intend only as part of our intending. The intentionality that exists in each individual head has the form ‘we intend.’

Such intentions are central to understanding group agency, in particular the phenomenon of formal organizations, such as firms, NGOs, institutions of higher learning, etc. These complex institutions account for an immense share of human activity and, not surprisingly, for a correspondingly immense share of the scholarly attention of social scientists. As a result, these are important objects of study in their own right.

Searle speculates that the capacity to engage in collective intentionality is a biological primitive in humans. Presumably, the idea is that the brain states activated by collective intentions are distinct from those activated by individual intentions. Some version of this view is widespread in the literature. For example, Tuomela refers to “we-mode” versus “I-mode” cognition.²⁰ While we agree that there is a real distinction between collective and individual intentions, the appeal to a special “mode” of cognition strikes us as ad-hoc. Instead, we argue that collective intentions arise as a result of individuals making deliberate decisions to relate themselves to others in the same way to the same object. By our account, this capacity uses precisely the *same* machinery of intelligence – insight, understanding, and judgment – that supports individual intentionalities.

²⁰**Tuomela1995.**

3 Social being

Earlier, we suggested that the “puzzle” of social facts seems to arise from an unexamined acceptance that ‘reality’ is somehow ‘out there,’ the focal point of sensitive extroversion. This, in turn, is linked to a view that presumes everything is ultimately reducible to some form of matter or energy or stuff intrinsically conditioned by space and time. The analysis that follows does not require us to take stand with respect to the reducibility of mind to purely material processes. It may very well be that when I shake my head, my ideas move back and forth with it. Rather, we simply observe that the baby of human intelligence seems to have been thrown out with the bathwater following the embrace of a reductionist philosophy of mind. As a result, the discussion of social reality has become – unnecessarily in our judgment – bogged down the welter of distinctions discussed above (‘mind-independence,’ and ‘mind-dependence,’ ‘observer-relative’ facts, ‘epistemic-’ versus ‘ontological-subjectivity,’ ‘intentional-relativity,’ and so on). Our position is that this tangle of distinctions is necessitated by the jarring absence of intelligence in the predominant accounts of social ontology.

The view expounded here is that, whatever that is to which it may (or may not) ultimately be reducible, human cognition exhibits a certain, well-defined structure that endows healthy people with a particular sort of intelligence. It is an intelligence characterized by the asking of questions, the grasping insights into the answers to these questions, the extension of these insights into understandings in the form of well-articulated concepts, the validation of such understandings based upon the relevant evidence, the relating of apparently valid understandings to extant bodies of knowledge, and so on. As Lonergan argues, that the human intellect exhibits these features is a self-appropriable fact for any healthy person to verify.

Specifically, following Lonergan, our position is that reality or being is what is to be known through correctly asking and answering questions. This means that even things and occurrences in the natural order are not reducible simply to their material element.

Consider asking, for instance, what a circle is. In the image of a circle we grasp the necessity of a uniform plane curve if the radii are all equal; and its impossibility, if the radii are unequal. This necessity and impossibility are grasped, not by reducing the circle to its material elements, but by understanding an intelligible ordering in the material. Necessity and impossibility are part of the intelligible reality of the circle, but they are not ‘out there’ to be imagined or inspected. Nor would we know what a circle is any better, if we were to reduce it to quantum mechanics.

Consider Searle’s contrast between the physical or natural order (ice on Everest, the composition of hydrogen) and the intentional order. We would say that the realities in the intentional order are at least partially constituted, not by opinion or belief, but by meaning. For instance, when we give a class lecture, we do not expect the students will understand what is ‘really’ going on by measuring and analyzing vibrations in the air emitting from our mouths. Of course, there are sound waves, and we are all for understanding them. But understanding the sound waves would not be understanding the lecture, for the lecture is an event partially constituted by meaning. It is an event in which we are arranging sounds, as conventional signs, with the purpose of communicating a meaning. Doubtless, if there were any mice in the room, they should not know what we were talking about. But we expect our students to catch on, and, in fact, we assess their comprehension as more or less adequate to our intended meaning.

This means, first of all, that accessibility to the sensorium of mice is not the criterion of reality. Rather, the criterion of reality is intelligent grasp and rational affirmation. The real meaning of the lecture is what would be known by understanding it correctly. Second, there is a hierarchical order to reality. The real meaning of the lecture does not in the least negate the reality of the vibrating vocal chords, the longitudinal waves in the air, the vibrating tympanum, the firing synapses. But understanding those realities would not be understanding the lecture. Understanding the lecture is understanding its meaning, and that meaning goes beyond, without in any way negating, the lower order realities that are

involved. Thus, one and the same reality may be analyzed from the standpoint of physics and chemistry, neuroscience and cognitive psychology; but its complete intelligibility includes its meaning, and, indeed, it is the meaning that in some way determines what sounds are made and what order they are made in. *Rem tene; verba sequentur.*²¹

This problem invites application of Lonergan's distinction between spheres of being. Being, or reality, is known by correctly understanding; and we confirm or disconfirm our understanding by formulating its implications and testing them against the available evidence. But the evidence must be construed in relation to some question, and as questions are of quite different kinds, so the relevant evidence differs. The evidence relevant to affirming the existence of ice atop Everest is different from the evidence relevant to affirming the logarithm of the square root of minus one, and both are different from affirming that the murderer was Professor Plum, in the drawing room, with the candlestick. But in each case, reaching a correct judgment is a matter of correctly construing the evidence in relation to a question, of grasping what the relevant conditions are, and ascertaining whether they have been fulfilled.²²

Now, social facts are facts about social being, and social being is at least partially constituted by meaning. The condition that distinguishes what we might call the sphere of 'intentional being' from other spheres, including what we might call 'natural being', is the occurrence of the relevant acts of meaning.⁵⁵ Note that for Lonergan, being constituted by meaning belongs to the sphere of 'real being'. But we are subdividing that sphere into what

²¹C. (Gaius) Julius Victor, *Ars rhetorica*, Library of Latin Texts (Turnhout: Brepols, 2010), I. "Grasp the thing, and the words will follow."

²²Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 75. ("We say that the moon exists. We also say that there exists the logarithm of the square root of minus one. In both cases we use the same verb, exist. But we do not mean that the moon is just a conclusion that can be deduced from suitable mathematical postulates, and we do not mean that the logarithm in question can be inspected sailing around the sky. A distinction, accordingly, has to be drawn between a sphere of real being and other restricted spheres such as the mathematical, the hypothetical, the logical, and so on. While the spheres differ enormously from each other, they are not simply disparate. The contents of each sphere are rationally affirmed. The affirmation is rational because it proceeds from an act of reflective understanding in which is grasped the virtually unconditioned, that is, a conditioned whose conditions are fulfilled. But the spheres differ so vastly because the conditions to be fulfilled differ.") A much ampler discussion of the problem of judgment and the different kinds of fulfilling conditions may be found in Lonergan, *Insight*, 3:296–340.

we might call ‘natural’ and ‘intentional’ real being. The condition that distinguishes social being, social facts, is the occurrence of the relevant acts of collective or social meaning. In other words, social facts are as real as any other facts, if the relevant conditions are fulfilled; but they differ in the sense that the conditions to be fulfilled include acts of meaning and, indeed, collective meaning. This eliminates the need for pseudo-metaphysical inventions like ‘ontologically subjective’ reality.²³

In summary, Lonergan clarifies the discussion in social ontology regarding the nature of social facts. Social facts are known like other facts: by grasping the fulfillment of the necessary and sufficient conditions. Social realities form a distinct sphere of being, since the conditions for their existence include common understanding, common judgment, and common consent. The fulfillment of the conditions is the extrinsic intelligibility of social being. Its intrinsic intelligibility is its meaning.

Meaning Meaning is an utterly polymorphic notion, and we do not propose a complete analysis of its kinds, elements, and functions.²⁴ Our more limited purpose will be served by drawing a few basic distinctions, which we will then illustrate with reference to the canonical example of a social being, money. Our central interest is in the connection between certain kinds of meaning, intelligence, and language. Therefore, we set aside, for the moment, considerations about the kind meaning that attaches to, say, a smile or a glower, a crucifix, a work of art, and the like. The reason is simple. To become constitutive of social being, in the sense intended here, it seems meaning must be (in some way) liberated from intersubjective spontaneity, psychic process, or restriction to particular types of media. This is the achievement of linguistic meaning. Here, then, let us make four points, seemingly elementary but highly significant, and then briefly illustrate their significance regarding the canonical

²³Searle, *The Construction of Social Reality*, 8. A reality is objective, if its conditions are fulfilled; and our knowing is objective, when, transcending our preferences, we face questions squarely and answer them correctly.⁷⁷On the notion of objectivity, see Lonergan, *Insight*, 3:399–409.

²⁴An initial orientation to such a project may be found in Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 57–99; Lonergan, *Insight*, 3:329–30, 381–83, 553–617.

example of the social convention, money.

Our first point is that linguistic meaning is the instrument of intelligence, and not, primarily, the instrument of some occult entity like Searle's 'Background', "the set of nonintentional or preintentional capacities that enable intentional states to function." The 'Background', of course, is a perfect illustration of the intelligent use of language to convey meaning, even if the meaning conveyed is the substitution of neurophysiological tarradiddle for an important event in consciousness, the insight. There is no doubt Searle had an insight when he invented his term; it surely correlated with neurological processes; but an attempt to reduce insight to neurological process would be hand-waving. It would be to overlook the significant, conscious process, which we have all experienced, of puzzling over a problem, trying to name (usually in a language) its salient elements, experiencing the dawn of light, working out the implications of one's ideas, checking them against the available evidence, and affirming or denying in just the measure permitted by the evidence.

Our second point is that a language is a set of conventional signs. This seems like a perfectly obvious thing to say, but its implications may be easily overlooked. The linguistic sign originates with an effort to communicate. It presupposes not only an idea to be communicated but also a further insight into the possibilities for getting it across to another. But because the other is also intelligent and catches on, and because the problem of communication is recurrent, there gradually occurs the accumulation of insights, not in a single subject but in many, by which a group builds up a set of conventional signs. Both in its original meaningfulness, then, and in its development into a social convention, language is the work of intelligence.

The social convention of language is part of the developed practical intelligence, the common sense, of every properly educated, socialized, acculturated member of a linguistic community.²⁵ The difference between our account and Searle's 'Background' is that our

²⁵We leave to one side, for the moment, the development specialized languages by subgroups within a sufficiently complex community. By common sense is meant "a nucleus of habitual insights such that the addition of one or two more will bring one to the understanding of any of an open series of concrete

account is not a plaster for an incoherently reductive metaphysics. Rather, it emerges organically from a position that takes questions and insight to be both real in themselves and the source of criteria for knowing reality.

Language, we said, is the instrument of intelligence, and our third point amplifies the meaning of instrument. Language is a carrier of meaning, and it carries meaning by a kind of participation in the meaningful intentions of speaking and listening (or writing and reading, etc.). Just as the brush produces a painting only by the hand of the artist, so the sounds convey an intended meaning only because they are intelligently ordered. Signs are meaningful as meant by someone, or as meaningful to someone, or both. Language, once it is a common possession, is invested with meaning both by the speaker and by the listener. The words are meaningful to the one as expressing her idea; and to the other, as an aural phantasm in which he might catch on to what is meant. An intelligent speaker grasps the possibilities for communication in the available language and by some effort to size up the hearers or readers. Someone who has understood a matter can talk about it in different ways as differences of audience or occasion demand. A translator can find the resources in a second language to approximate the meaning expressed in the first. An exam is meant to distinguish the students who have understood from those who are merely repeating the words.

Such intentions, of course, are not in some free vacuum. Not only is the meaning expressed in the context of a conventional system; normally it is also worked out discursively, so that language is not only a carrier of meaning from one incarnate subject to another, but also a carrier of thought in the first. The available language molds consciousness, so that it is easy to notice what we can name and difficult to notice what we cannot, and so on.²⁶ At

situations,” “a large and floating population of elementary judgments which everyone makes, everyone relies upon, and almost everyone regards as obvious and indisputable.”⁴⁴Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 72–73; Lonergan, *Insight*, 3:314.

²⁶The matter is quite complex, and cannot be explored here. For illustrations, going beyond language, see Mary Douglas, *How Institutions Think*, 1st ed., Frank W. Abrams Lectures (Syracuse, N.Y.: Syracuse University Press, 1986); Mary Douglas, *Essays in the Sociology of Perception* (Boston: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1982).

the same time, it is also the case that there are new discoveries and people find a way to talk about them. A language may be conventional, but that does not entail that only what is conventional may be meant in it. The original mind must bend the language to work out her ideas and to express them.

Let us return, fourth, to the point with which we started this section, the notable freedom of linguistic carriers of meaning. This notable freedom is the result of an insight into the possibility of investing any suitable sound, or any suitable token, with meaning. In itself, the token is just the material part of the sign; it is what may be invested with meaning and, once mutual understanding is achieved, may be invested with common meaning. Any group that has achieved the linguistic stage of development has grasped the possibility of conventional signs; and any group that has achieved the literary stage has grasped the convertibility of conventional signs (that is, the representation of sounds by letters, or of ideas by pictures or sounds). This convertibility adds a further dimension of liberation to linguistic meaning. It is free, relative to intersubjective, artistic, and symbolic meaning; but now it is also relatively unconstrained by time and space. It is a matter of simple practical insight to endow other tokens with even more complex meanings.

Meaning as a constituent of social reality Their native language is probably the most ineluctable social convention for the members of a social group. It is also foundational, it seems to us, for many other types of social convention. In our analysis of language, we were led to distinguish the instrument from the intention; the former is participatively meaningful by sharing the basic meaningfulness of the latter. If they were not at least distinct, anything like translation, explanation in other words, etc. would be impossible. Let us turn now to a consideration of money as a social fact.

Before it was analyzed by economists and philosophers, money was an invention of practical intelligence, the solution to practical problems of exchange. It was invented in the places where those problems occurred, and not among groups where they did not, not because it

involves a stroke of genius but because intelligence works on problems. If we prescind from accidental factors (such as taxation), we might hypothesize the following ideal sequence of four essential insights culminating in the convention of a fiat currency. Our point here, it must be stressed, is nothing like a history of money or a thorough analysis of money or its functions. Our point is simply that, if one acknowledges the reality of intelligence, one has no need to invent occult entities to hypothesize how the social convention of money might develop.

First, then, there is the problem of commensurate exchange, which does not arise in groups small and close enough to enforce the slogan of Karl Marx. Barter requires a limited set of insights: measuring the value of X (to me, and to you) against the value of Y (to me, and to you), to determine some mutually satisfactory ratio of exchange. We leave to one side the problem of my estimate of your appraisal and your estimate of mine; what is essential is the possibility of a commensuration of values, and an agreement to trade. (The problem of regulating weights and measures, to say nothing of enforcement, is not far behind; and with it, the involvement of public authority.)

Next, the practical problems of barter elicit a further insight: the possibility of a single, divisible standard against which other values might be measured, for instance, coin and bullion (stamped, for good measure, by public authority). Precious materials, however, have their own impracticalities as a medium of exchange, and when these are joined with insight into the possibility of conventional signs (an insight enjoyed by everyone who learns any language), there occurs, third, the possibility of receipts or certificates, representing the standard measure, as instruments of exchange; in places where there is a functioning public authority, the widespread adoption of such instruments the ready transition from private to publicly sanctioned notes.

Finally, it is a small step for intelligence, faced with (say) a shortage of gold, to grasp that what is essential is simply an independent, standard measure as an instrument of exchange. Then the currency simply represents relative economic value directly, rather

than indirectly by representing the value of a given commodity, such as a quantity of gold. Thus, a comparatively simple sequence of practical insights leads ultimately to fiat currencies sanctioned, regulated, and required (e.g., for payment of tax) by public authority.

We have been focusing on the emergence of the ideas, but there is also the matter of their initial dissemination, and the subsequent socialization of new members. The initial dissemination is the matter of one person making another understand an idea that is not so unfamiliar as to be outlandish, and persuading her to go along. Since exchange requires coordination, in the genesis there is the matter of explaining, of persuading, of deciding to coordinate choices. But once the functioning scheme of recurrence is established, there is little need for explanation (the ubiquity of experience elicits the required insights without a midwife), almost none for persuasion, and the coordination occurs almost as a matter of course, since it is merely a matter of taking one's part in a ready-made world. The requisite insights occur so early and so imperceptibly, and the evidence for their correctness so ubiquitous, that almost no one can remember having them. The practical person is not, after all, conducting a theoretical analysis of the set-up; her correct understanding of the usefulness of money is repeatedly confirmed.

Again, we are not pretending to an economic analysis of money or a history of its development. Our purpose is extremely limited: it is to explain how a social convention like money might come to be through a few simple insights. In discussing language, we noted the importance of distinguishing the instrument from the intention, and it is similar here. Paper money is an instrument of meaning; but a letter of credit, a plastic card, an electronic account are equally instruments of the same meaning. The fundamental issue is the emergence of the intentions, i.e., the coalescence and accumulation of practical insights, judgments, and decisions. Note, however, that the intentions and the instrument, while distinct, are not separate; for the intention is to use an instrument, and while any suitable token will do in the abstract, in the concrete the suitable token is the one everyone else recognizes. Moreover, the reality in question is not 'subjective'. If the conditions are fulfilled – if some group agrees

to use money as a measure of economic value and a medium of exchange – then they have, objectively, created money.

This is in the same sense that a carpenter might create a chair. The difference is that a chair is not partially constituted by meaning; money is. Even so, money is real; it is a conditioned possibility whose conditions are, in fact, fulfilled. What is that reality? It is the reality of a practical understanding, become common to many, to make use of these tokens for measurement and exchange; it is the reality of the judgments, common to many, that it is worthwhile to participate; and their consequent decisions (daily ratified) to participate. This analysis suggests that money is fundamentally a convention, that is, a social practice, and only derivatively a social artifact. The social practice requires instruments – currency either as printed or represented in some other way – but the meaning of the instrument is derived from the convention, the social performance. Our conclusion is similar to Searle's, but our reasoning is different.

The analysis might be generalized to take in other conventions. For instance, in a contract, we distinguish the instrument expressing an undertaking (the written document), from the undertaking itself (that is, the mutual understanding and agreement of the parties, including their decision to publically bind themselves). A distinction, however, is not a separation. Social realities, constituted by meaning, are intrinsically public. And they can be intrinsically public, only if the intention includes the expression. Thus, laws are promulgated, appointments are announced, contracts are signed, and none of them are complete without the instrumental act of meaning. Any resolution of such realities into their intrinsic ontological constituents, then, must account for their intrinsically public character; that is, the link between intention and expression is among the necessary and sufficient conditions for their existence. Notice, too, the significance of our distinction between the social and the cultural; the same contractual arrangements may exist in different cultural settings that assign different values to, e.g., honor or solidarity.

Collective intentionality I may use ‘our language’ to say what ‘I mean,’ regardless of your intentions. If we exchange goods with ‘our currency’ further coordination is necessary: I intend to buy what you intend to sell, so we are each intending the same object; in fact, buying and selling are an identity in the sense that one and the same event is selling, from one standpoint, and buying, from another. This one event, as partially constituted by meaning, depends on the coordinated intentions of the subjects involved.

By collective intentionality, social ontologists mean some sense in which the members of a group share an intention, such as common understanding, common judgment or evaluation, common or coordinated decisions or commitments. The literature exhibits some divergence on what it means to say an intention is shared. At one end of the spectrum, authors like List and Pettit claim that collective intentionality is limited to sets of individuals who “form and act on a single, robustly rational body of attitudes.”²⁷ By this definition, collective intentionality is essentially decomposable to the intentions of the individual members of the group. At the other end of the spectrum, Huebner argues for a “macrocognition,” a sort of collective meta-mind that arises from the interaction of a “distributed system” of individual minds.²⁸

While the identification of collective intentionality with a group-level meta-mind seems too strong, the claim that any behavior occurring at a group level is nothing more than a coordinated set of individual intentions seems too weak. Rather, the proposition is that ‘we intend’ implies a kind of intention, a grasp of the kinds of situations in which such an intention may arise, and an understanding of the difference between ‘our intention’ from ‘my intention.’ Thus, a collective intention is not simply a species of individual intention modified by some accidental qualification. The intention is different in the sense that it is intelligently related to the expressed intentions of the others and cannot be understood apart

²⁷List/Pettit: Group agency: the possibility, design, and status of corporate agents (see n. 4), zzz Page number needed.

²⁸Bryce Huebner: *Macro cognition: A Theory of Distributed Minds and Collective Intentionality*, New York 2014, zzz page number needed.

from those relationships.

Consider a case of collective action. Liam and Robyn are working together on a joint research project. Their collective goal is to establish new findings, to be communicated in a coauthored paper. The initiation of the joint work may be preceded by explicit negotiations regarding the aims, the distribution of work, method, the order in which their names are to appear on a paper, and so on. Or, the project may arise organically, following discussions over biscotti at their favorite hipster coffee bar, slowly evolving over several months of exchange. At some point, without, perhaps, any explicit agreement, they come to understand themselves as working together on a joint project. Even without explicit agreement, if Robyn should suddenly cease all communication, Liam may legitimately feel he has the right to ask what is going on. Indeed, if the answer is not forthcoming or does not seem adequate, Liam may reproach her according to his sense that their shared intention has been violated. As long as the project continues, each of them will take individual actions toward the completion of their shared goal.

One might ask, however, if the notion of the collective intention does not create an infinite regress: we have an agreement because we believe we have an agreement, because we believe we believe we have an agreement, and so on. The answer is that there is an agreement *if the conditions for an agreement are fulfilled* and, because no one can inhabit another's consciousness, those conditions do include believing one another. However, because intentions are inherently relational, they can be coordinated so that multiple subjects regard the same real object and, in fact, regard it as if they were one in their regard. Liam can truly report to Robyn his conditional intention to work together, and vice versa. If *each finds sufficient evidence to believe the other's report*, then each is entirely rational to accept it and would be irrational not to. The report of each to the other fulfills the condition upon the intention of the other, and the fulfillment of these conditions completes the circle: a collective intention exists.

The collective intention is a joint or at least a mutual undertaking, and a joint expression

of that undertaking. It does not seem enough to say that it is a matter of ‘I intend and you intend’: it is that ‘we intend’. There is, of course, a kind of ‘prior we’ involved in the acquisition and use of ‘our language’ and ‘our money’; but a collective intention somehow constitutes a ‘consequent we’. Both the ‘prior’ and the ‘consequent’ we intentional, that is, involve us in understanding, judgment, decisions that are not in a vacuum but are related to others; yet the ‘consequent we’ is more. It is a deliberate decision to relate ourselves in the same way to the same object. Our contention is not for a kind of group-level consciousness; rather, we claim that persons have the basic cognitive capacity to distinguish that ‘my intention’ versus ‘our intention’ represent importantly different kinds of intending.²⁹

Gilbert discusses an important class of cases of this type, in which the members “publicly express a commonly understood commitment to endorse an intention as a single body.”³⁰ This involves two distinct elements: a joint commitment, such that none can renege without answering to the others; and a commitment to emulate the intention as a single entity. The first aspect (joint commitment) has been visited above, but the second deserves a moment of elaboration. The emulation of a single entity requires that the general form of the joint commitment be: “The parties within our group are jointly committed to Φ as a body,” where Φ is a placeholder for some relevant intention.⁸⁸ Adapting Ibid., 7. For Gilbert, Φ denotes any verb, i.e., cases in which the commitment is to take actions in the service of a common goal. What the individuals are committing themselves to is emulating as a group, “by virtue of the acts of each, a single Φ -er.” Thus, the joint commitment gives rise to a collective intention (singular) of the group; it is an intention of them all such that it is coherent to say “they are the subject, it is theirs.” Anyone who fails to so act is in breach of the commitment and open to censure. Each member is committed to act in fulfillment of the shared intention,

²⁹This claim about cognitional capacity is not uncontested. For example, Tollefsen characterizes the debate as between ‘methodological individualism’ (according to which group phenomena can only be explained in terms of the psychological states of individual members), and ‘methodological collectivism’ (which holds that “irreducible group-level properties” are required to explain group phenomena). (Tollefsen, *Groups as Agents*, 4.)

³⁰**Gilbert 2013.**

even in the face of unanticipated events. For example, when the squad commits to taking the hill, every member is pledged to do his or her variable part to realize the squad's goal. Of course, it should be added that such commitments need not be unconditional.

4 Formal organizations

It is widely acknowledged that formal organizations, such as corporations, universities and the like, are partially constituted by culture. Therefore, let us begin with a mainstream conception of culture.

Culture According to Schein, a culture is

... a pattern of shared basic assumptions learned by a group as it solved its problems of external adaptation and internal integration, which has worked well enough to be considered valid and, therefore, to be taught to new members as the correct way to perceive, think, and feel in relation to those problems.³¹

As he explains,

Culture is both a 'here and now' dynamic phenomenon and a coercive background structure that influences us in multiple ways... When we are influential in shaping the behavior and values of others, we think of that as 'leadership' and are creating the conditions for new culture formation. At the same time, culture implies stability and rigidity in the sense that how we are supposed to perceive, feel, and act... has been taught to us by our various socialization experiences and becomes prescribed as a way to maintain the 'social order'.³²

³¹Schein2010.

³²Schein2010.

Education, socialization, and enculturation result in a kind of second spontaneity legitimizing the practices and institutions of our practical living. Schein distinguishes the elements of culture into a hierarchy: (1) artifacts, (2) beliefs and values, and (3) assumptions. In the first category he locates visible structures and observed behavior. The second and the third differ inasmuch as the beliefs and values of the second level are thematic, explicitly named, espoused by the group, while the assumptions of the third level are unobjectified. Thus, pertaining to the second level would be the espoused beliefs, goals, and values shared by the group, remain part of its focal awareness and, often, are embodied in its statement of organizational philosophy (e.g., ‘we value teamwork’). The assumptions of the third level, on the other hand, “have become so taken for granted that you find little variation within a social unit . . . members will find behavior based on any other premise inconceivable.”³³ There is no need to bring such assumptions into focus by naming them explicitly.

Let us now add some further distinctions, broadly applicable but briefly illustrated with reference to a firm. First, we distinguish four levels of value, in an ascending hierarchy: (1) particular goods, (2) organization or order, (3) culture, and (4) agents.³⁴ By particular goods we mean products, services, and activities of the firm. By organization or order, we mean the network of actually existing relationships among the members of the firm. Order is not reducible to particular goods, but is the intelligent division and coordination of roles and tasks that ensures a regular delivery of particular goods and services, a regular occurrence of coordinated activities. By culture, we mean the set of meanings and values that inform and validate the firm’s way of proceeding: its organization and order, that is, and the particular goods and services it provides and pursues. We are suggesting that the organization of a firm, and its pursuits, are distinguishable from the culture that endows them with meaning and value. Thus, two firms may provide the same services and have virtually identical organizations, yet operate on the basis of different shared meanings and

³³**Schein2010.**

³⁴Derived from Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 31–32, 47–52. See too Patrick H. Byrne, *The Ethics of Discernment: Lonergan’s Foundations for Ethics* (Toronto: University of Toronto, 2016), 241–84.

values. Fourth, finally, are the agents, the persons, who act for purposes, who coordinate their actions, who endow their activities with meaning and value, and who by their collective activities constitute the firm.

Next, let us correlate our division with Schein's account by distinguishing explicit from tacit elements in a culture. Explicit elements are part of focal awareness, thematically objectified as the meanings and values of the firm. Tacit elements are the meanings and values operative in consciousness but unnamed and taken for granted. But the picture is complicated by considering that each agent also brings to the table her or his own horizon, what she is capable of noticing, prepared to acknowledge, ready to wonder about, to take seriously, to affirm or deny, to choose or reject. So, the actual situation will be a compound of common meanings and values that are explicit, common meanings and values that have their influence but are not named, and the horizons of the agents who come together in the firm.

Third, we further distinguish actual from potential cultures. A culture obtains because the conditions for its obtaining have been fulfilled and continue to be fulfilled. An obtaining culture is "virtually unconditioned," that is, it has conditions but they have been fulfilled. Potential cultures, on the other hand, would become operative if some presumably feasible set of conditions were to be fulfilled; what those conditions are, and how they might be practically fulfilled, is the problem of management and strategy. However, this account is also relevant to the question of the ontological status of the firm, as we shall see.

Finally, let us distinguish two kinds of data on culture: public and private. Public data are externally observable; they include expressions of meaning such as slogans, awards, and memos; the actual allocation of time and resources to various activities and pursuits; the kinds of products and services provided; the pace of, and responses to, invention, innovation, enterprise; etc. But if a culture is a set of meanings and values that inform a way of proceeding, then, arguably, the consciousness of the agents themselves is highly relevant to an interpretation of culture. Such data are not accessible, except indirectly, to anyone but

the agents themselves. This is true, however, not only for the theorist of culture but also for the participants, who must coordinate their activities based on suppositions about the aims and intentions of the others. We do not have an easy solution to this investigative problem, but we point it out for two reasons. The first is to resist reductive interpretations that would obscure the fact that the agency in question is conscious, that personal action is informed by meaning and motivated by value, and these are not to be known simply by reducing them to the correlative brain-states. The second is to suggest that investigators verify in their own experience, by some form of scientific self-attention, such conscious phenomena as inquiry, discovery, formulation; reflection on the evidence, and judgment; apprehension of value, deliberation, and choice; and the like. For, at the end of the day, these are the kinds of realities we are getting at when we ask about the meanings and values that inform and motivate a way of proceeding.

Organizations The danger of attempting to distinguish kinds of social being is that one is easily mistaken for pretending a complete list. We are not. It will be helpful, however, to distinguish conventions, organizations, artifacts, and events. These are all social objects, that is, entities that are intended and constituted by meaning. Further, the notion of collective intentionality allows us to speak of social subjects that are also constituted by meaning, not as intended but as collectively intending. In our preceding example, Liam and Robyn would count as a social subject; their intentions are so related that those intentions simply could not exist alone; it is an intrinsically collective intending.

Social artifacts are stable expressions or instruments whose meaning is in some way constituted by common understanding, common assent, and common consent. For instance, a banknote is a social artifact. Social conventions are legitimated and sanctioned behaviors that are part and parcel of a community's common sense, for instance, passing on the right, stopping for a red light, waiting in line. Social events are occasions whose reality is constituted by a common understanding of their meaning, such as a commencement exercise or

a wedding. Social organizations are stable frameworks for cooperation. An organization is distinct from a group, just as convention is distinct from purely provisional, temporary, ad hoc arrangements that are recognized as such. Both social conventions and social organizations are legitimized in the sense that, if challenged, they can appeal to cultural assumptions about ‘the way things are’.³⁵

Any organization is a (deliberately conceived, stable) framework for cooperation. As a framework, an organization is a pattern or complex of relations. It relates different roles to one another, and assigns tasks and powers to roles. Skills are perfections in the individual that relate her potentially to others; roles are assigned places in a scheme or framework of cooperation. The framework is dynamic; it is an assembly of recurrent schemes interrelating performers and recurring performances.

The origin of the framework is in some set of practical insights about how to get things done. The insights are successfully communicated to others who are persuaded to cooperate. Normally a person of common sense has learned how to cooperate and, unless some radically new template is proposed, it is not too difficult to add the insights specific to this framework. Once the framework is established, individuals are remotely capable of joining it to the extent that they may develop the proportionate skills; and proximately capable to the extent that they actually possess the skills appropriate to some role in the institution.

What is the reality of the framework? In its base, it is the reality of common and complementary understandings in the participants, of common judgments regarding both the way things work and the values of the cooperative, of a basic decision to participate. As a dynamic, ongoing reality, it is also the reality of the daily insights, judgments, and decisions, on the part of many different persons, into what needs to be done for each to fulfill her role, complete her tasks, and advance the objectives of the cooperative. All of these are not merely common in the sense that I understand what money is and you understand what money is; they are common in the sense of a collective intentionality.

³⁵Douglas, *How Institutions Think*, 42.

But one may ask if such an organization as a firm has, as such, its own proper identity, whether it is only a complex of interrelated things or is a unity, a center of identity, a whole in and of itself.³⁶ When we predicate a history of Ford, or the objectives of Apple, what is the real, ontological subject of that predication? Is it the many, interrelated persons who at various times and in various ways have played roles and fulfilled tasks in the framework of those institutions? If the history of Ford is a complex of interrelated events, and the present reality of Ford is a complex of interrelated persons exercising roles and performing tasks, is there no ontologically stable ‘thing’ that is Ford?

It is in no way decisive for this question to observe that the law treats a corporation as a legal person. Yet it is a highly interesting fact, for the law means to establish a stable center of identity—and, for that matter, the officers of a corporation mean to act (within a limited frame) on its behalf. They understand themselves to be related to one another through their relation to a common object, the firm. In this sense, a firm is a different kind of social grouping than, say, a marriage, which relates two persons to each other. A marriage is a collective intention, but it does not relate the spouses to one another through some third, as it were, independent center of identity; and if one of the spouses passes away, the marriage ceases to be. The firm, on the other hand, while very far from subsuming or destroying the independent identities of its parties, nevertheless is itself a kind of center of identity to which they each and collectively relate themselves. What is important here is the decision to emulate a unity by constituting an entity, distinct from themselves and to which they then relate themselves, but only, as it were, accidentally. Individuals are fungible in relation to the stable identity of the firm.

In some sense, the notions of a socially constructed object and a socially constructing subject seem to coincide in the firm. We expect this peculiarity to prove highly relevant to understanding corporate culture and the sense in which the firm is a kind of agent. In the sequel we would like to consider this question at greater length.

³⁶On the notion of the ‘thing’, that is, a “unity, identity, whole in data,” see Lonergan, *Insight*, 3:270-95.

5 Conclusion

In this paper, we urge a non-reductive analysis of social being grounded on insight and collective intentionality. We distinguish between a social arrangement, the meaning ascribed to it, and the agents who are severally or collectively involved in the ascription. Our analysis grounds the objectivity of social reality in the virtually unconditioned. Just as the language of our dinner conversation is really and objectively English even though our dogs have never succeeded in acquiring the language despite years of overhearing it, so a dollar is really and objectively the currency of some group even if the member of some primitive society has not got the faintest inkling about money. Further, our analysis, because it is non-reductive and because it distinguishes the intention from the token, easily explains both why some paper is objectively money and why, though really and truly money, it does not cease to be paper.

Again, because we ground our analysis on insight, we have no trouble accounting for the intrinsic constitutive function of meaning. By the same token, we account for the possibility of collective intentions whose intrinsic reality could not obtain in the solitary individual. Finally, we raise a question about the peculiar ontology of the firm as a reality, constituted by meaning, and intended as a distinct and stable center of its own identity. While we do not pretend to have exhausted these topics, we hope enough has been said to indicate the promise of this line of analysis, and, perhaps, to at least suggest why the peculiar intentionality involved in the constitution of a firm may be relevant to an analysis of its culture.